

57.2 "COULD" FOR PAST ABILITIES

"Could" is the past form of "can" and is used to talk about an ability in the past. "When" plus a time setting can be used to say when someone had the ability.



The time frame can be set with a phrase about an age, day, or year.

I can't climb trees now, but **I could** when I was younger.

Describes a present ability.

Describes a past ability.

FURTHER EXAMPLES

When I was a student, **I could** study all night before an exam.



When Milo was eight, **he could** play the violin.



Negative form.

I couldn't go to China last year because it was too expensive.



Last year **she couldn't** run very far, but yesterday she ran a marathon.



57.3 "CAN" IN THE FUTURE

It is not grammatically possible to talk about the future using "can." "Will be able to" is used instead.

At the moment, **I can** play the trombone quite well.



If I work harder, **I will be able to** play at concerts.

"Will can" is incorrect.

The negative is formed with "not able to" or "unable to."

Unfortunately, **I can't** read music very well.



If I don't learn, **{ I won't be able to / will be unable to }** join the orchestra.

"Will be unable to" can also be used, but it's less common.